

AI Tool Evaluation Process - Executive Summary

Author: Cash Myers

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Purpose

This summary provides a quick first-pass response to the preliminary AI tool evaluation matrix.

The current matrix is a useful starting point and can support the Council's immediate review of tools such as GitHub and Figma. The goal of this feedback is not to slow down today's review or prevent the Council from making progress.

Instead, the recommendation is to use today's matrix as a discussion aid while developing a more robust evaluation process for future AI tool reviews.

Bottom Line

The current matrix asks an important first question:

- Is this a good tool?

For future reviews, the process should also ask:

- Is this tool appropriate for this specific use case?
- With what data?
- For which users?
- Under what conditions?
- With what monitoring?
- For how long before re-review?

That shift would make AI tool approvals more repeatable, defensible, and easier to document in the approved AI tool inventory.

What the Current Matrix Already Does Well

The existing matrix identifies many of the right evaluation areas:

- strategic fit
- academic integrity
- privacy and security
- accessibility and equity
- pedagogical value
- user experience
- LMS and IT integration
- vendor viability
- cost effectiveness
- legal, IP, and accountability risks

These categories are useful and should be preserved.

Key Improvement Needed

The next version should connect tool evaluation to approval conditions.

An AI tool should not be approved only by name. Approval should be tied to:

- approved use cases
- approved user groups
- approved data classifications
- required restrictions
- required training or documentation
- monitoring expectations
- review or renewal timeline

For example, a tool may be appropriate for public-facing design drafts or synthetic classroom examples, but not appropriate for student records, employee records, confidential advising notes, or high-impact institutional decisions.

Recommended Process Direction

The evaluation process should likely include five parts:

1. **Intake Summary** Identify the tool, requestor, owner, intended use, user group, cost, data types, and integrations.
2. **Gating Questions** Identify whether the tool involves student records, employee records, confidential or restricted data, external vendor accounts, model training, enterprise integrations, accessibility concerns, or high-impact decisions.
3. **Scored Evaluation** Use the existing matrix categories, but add weighting or risk sensitivity where appropriate.
4. **Decision Summary** Record the approval status, risk tier, approved use cases, prohibited use cases, approved data classes, restrictions, owner, and renewal date.
5. **Ongoing Monitoring** Track vendor changes, incidents, user feedback, accessibility issues, contract changes, and re-review dates.

Suggested Approval Statuses

Future reviews may benefit from more specific outcomes than simple approval or rejection:

- Approved
- Approved for Pilot
- Approved with Conditions
- Approved for Limited Use
- Academic Review Required
- ITS/Security Review Required
- Legal/Contract Review Required
- Rejected
- Suspended
- Retired

These statuses would help the AI tool inventory communicate not just whether a tool is approved, but how it is approved.

Recommended Immediate Use

For today's review, the Council can use the existing matrix to support discussion and keep momentum.

At minimum, the Council should try to document:

- the specific use case being reviewed
- who will use the tool
- what data may be entered into the tool
- whether student, employee, confidential, or restricted data is involved
- whether the tool integrates with college systems
- whether students are required to create external accounts

- whether vendor terms allow submitted data to train external models
- whether accessibility documentation exists
- whether the decision is full approval, pilot approval, or conditional approval
- who owns training, support, monitoring, and renewal

Suggested Next Step

After today's meeting, the evaluation process can be strengthened into a more complete AI tool review workflow.

The immediate opportunity is to turn the current matrix into a repeatable approval system that supports innovation while respecting federal, state, local, and institutional requirements around privacy, accessibility, academic integrity, security, records, procurement, and human accountability.